HUMAN RESOURCES SYSTEMS AND OPERATIONAL CONTROLS

UKG HRIS Modernization, Data Integrity and Operational Controls

Improving the reliability of employee records, reducing manual administration, and developing practical controls and training during a complex system transition.

Family Solutions

Operations Manager and designated UKG HRIS Administrator

Executive overview

At Family Solutions, I identified risks associated with disconnected timekeeping and payroll systems, manual employee documentation, and paper personnel files. I advocated for an integrated HRIS for nearly two years because these were not isolated administrative inconveniences. They affected data accuracy, employee privacy, payroll reliability, and the organization's ability to monitor its own processes.

When new leadership approved an HRIS initiative, I participated in the vendor evaluations and was selected as the system administrator regardless of which product was chosen. The HR Director served as the formal implementation lead. I held the secondary implementation role, with significant responsibility for preparing and validating migration data, coordinating required documentation, designing workflows, and building reporting and electronic forms. UKG was ultimately selected, and I developed the technical and operational knowledge needed to make it useful for our organization.

My work extended beyond the initial rollout. I identified implementation gaps, built compliance and exception reports, developed training resources, and supported managers and employees through the transition. Some departments adopted the system successfully, while inconsistent follow-through in other areas continued to require additional oversight. The project demonstrates how I approach a complex implementation: protect the integrity of the data, make the processes usable, identify risks early, and improve what can be improved.

The starting point and immediate problem

Family Solutions used QuickBooks Desktop for payroll and StratusTime for timekeeping, while employee records included extensive paper documentation. At times, sensitive paper files were not secured consistently. When StratusTime stopped importing into QuickBooks, approximately 60 employees' hours were at risk of requiring manual reentry, creating both administrative burden and unnecessary opportunities for error.

Before the HRIS project was approved, I troubleshot the StratusTime issue and developed a way to import the timekeeping information into QuickBooks again. This protected the payroll process from a major increase in manual work while I continued advocating for a more complete solution.

System evaluation and implementation responsibilities

The selection process involved approximately 20 vendor presentations. I participated in the evaluations, provided operational and technical input, and was designated to administer whichever HRIS was selected. After UKG was selected, I focused on making the chosen system work effectively for our organization.

A substantial part of my implementation work involved data preparation. Rather than manually transcribing employee information into the vendor's required spreadsheets, I created an SQL script to extract and reshape existing data into a CSV format that could be transferred into the prescribed worksheets. I validated the output and coordinated or directed the collection of additional reports and documentation. This approach reduced repetitive entry and, more importantly, reduced the risk of introducing errors into employee records.

I supplied the necessary source reports and supporting information for the parallel payroll testing conducted by UKG's implementation team. My responsibilities centered on technical preparation, data integrity, workflow development, and ongoing system administration.

Electronic documentation and business process design

Digital forms and employee records

I recreated the existing printed new-hire forms in UKG's form-building tools and configured fields to populate automatically where possible. This reduced repetitive writing and manual HR entry while helping organize required documentation in one system. Employees could maintain information through self-service, including direct deposit details, removing an unnecessary HR transcription step and its associated error risk.

I also designed a handbook receipt acknowledgment that required employees to access and download the employee handbook before signing electronically. The completed form created a documented record of handbook distribution and employee acknowledgment in UKG.

Role-based routing and approvals

I worked with UKG's implementation staff to design workflows around job titles and responsibilities rather than named individuals wherever possible. For example, IT Specialist was a designated recipient of employee start and separation requests for account access and equipment. This allowed the workflow to continue when someone changed positions or left the organization.

Approval paths reflected the type of request. Some processes required two sequential approvals, involving roles such as program management and the HR Director; others routed to HR, IT, or the appropriate supervisor. Timecards were set up with two authorized approvers to maintain coverage. Where a department had only one manager, that manager's supervisor could serve as the alternate. As HRIS Administrator, I retained organization-wide visibility and approval access for oversight and exception handling.

Administrative and reporting improvements

UKG supported electronic PTO requests, mileage reimbursements, personnel changes, and other forms. I could check required supporting documents before approving mileage reimbursements. I developed reports that replaced previous QuickBooks reports and helped with credentialing by showing which employee documents were already available and which were missing. The credentialing team could then send an electronic request through UKG rather than manually reconstructing the file status.

Implementation challenges and corrective controls

The technical rollout moved ahead faster than some managers were prepared to adopt it. I had recommended earlier communication and structured change management, but managers received limited advance preparation. Only two of ten managers had attended the available training before the previous timekeeping system was scheduled to stop. As routine questions and errors emerged, I developed practical safeguards rather than relying on repeated last-minute corrections.

New-hire documentation monitoring

During the first month after full implementation, I discovered that an employee had begun working at a job site without completing required I-9 documentation. Because the employee worked weekends and payroll was approaching, I went to the location on a Saturday to help resolve the issue. I then created weekly reports sent to HR staff and department managers identifying newly hired employees with outstanding required documentation. This turned a late discovery into a recurring compliance check.

Exception reports and support tracking

I created additional reports to surface possible problems, including instances in which time off was approved without sufficient available leave and patterns suggesting supervisors needed more instruction. I also added a dedicated UKG support category to the Genuity technology support portal, routing those requests to me. Tracking issues by employee, manager, and topic made it easier to identify repeated questions, direct coaching where it was needed, and maintain visibility into unresolved problems.

Training, feedback and adoption

I developed role-specific PowerPoint presentations and short guides for employees and managers. Employee materials addressed login, mobile access, clocking in and out, PTO, schedule changes, and shift coverage requests. Manager materials addressed timecard approvals, performance reviews, and other supervisory responsibilities. The guides were stored in SharePoint so people could revisit the steps when needed.

I treated training as an ongoing process. I asked participants for feedback, revised slides when instructions were unclear, and met with managers and employees both in person and through Microsoft Teams for individual demonstrations. Several managers said the presentations were useful, and some outside my reporting line improved their use of UKG and contributed feedback that strengthened the resources.

The departments I directly managed adopted UKG successfully, including maintenance employees who were not especially comfortable with technology. After training, direct reports generally handled their normal responsibilities independently and knew they could ask questions when unusual situations arose. I made help available without treating questions as a failure.

Results and management insights

The implementation improved the handling of required employee paperwork, centralized record access, reduced manual entry of direct deposit information, and made documentation for reimbursements and credentialing easier to verify. SQL-based data preparation reduced the risk of migration errors. Weekly compliance reports, exception reporting, and a dedicated support channel provided better visibility into issues that previously could have gone unnoticed until a deadline or complaint.

User adoption varied across the organization. Employees in my departments became proficient, and several managers in other departments demonstrated meaningful improvement. Continued monitoring identified opportunities for additional training, clearer responsibilities, and more consistent use of established processes.

This experience reinforced a principle I apply to every implementation: technical deployment is only one part of operational change. Accurate data, understandable workflows, accessible training, clear ownership, and consistent management support must work together. My approach is to anticipate these needs early, build practical solutions, and continuously improve processes based on actual user experiences and operational results.